

Match the Player, Not the Game: An Exploratory Study of Personality-Adaptive Tutorial Design in Souls-like Games.

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INTRODUCTION

- Souls-like games are defined by punishing difficulty and minimal onboarding
- Players differ in Openness to Experience — curiosity vs. preference for structure
- Person-Environment Fit theory predicts matching conditions to personality improves outcomes

METHODS

- N = 29 · 2×2 between-subjects pilot · Game: Lies of P
- BFI-10 personality questionnaire → median split (High / Low Openness)
- Minimal tutorial: genre-typical discovery-based play. Explicit tutorial: 8-page PDF guide before gameplay
- DVs: Enjoyment, Perceived Competence, Intention to Continue (7-pt scales)
- Type III ANOVA · sum-to-zero contrasts · Benjamini-Hochberg FDR

RESULTS

- Personality type alone didn't change outcomes — no tutorial worked clearly better for any group
- No guide = more competent: players without a guide felt more capable (5.1/7) than those with one (3.8/7) — opposite of what was expected
- Enjoyment was identical across all groups (5.0–5.6/7) — changing tutorials doesn't hurt the fun
- Boss completion was similar: 79% (no guide) vs. 73% (with guide) — the guide didn't make it easier

DISCUSSION

- Why the guide may have backfired: Explicit guidance sets expectations — souls-like games break them. Players without a guide had nothing to fail against.
- Openness isn't enough: Conscientiousness — preference for structure is the missing trait. A High-O / Low-C player won't engage with a guide regardless of quality.
- Personality self-report has an honesty problem: When answers visibly change outcomes, players game the system (see PMD). Behaviour inference from the first 5 minutes of play can't be faked.
- Next step: N ≈ 90–100, stratified on prior experience, Openness × Conscientiousness × Tutorial design, in-game unavoidable tutorial instead of PDF.

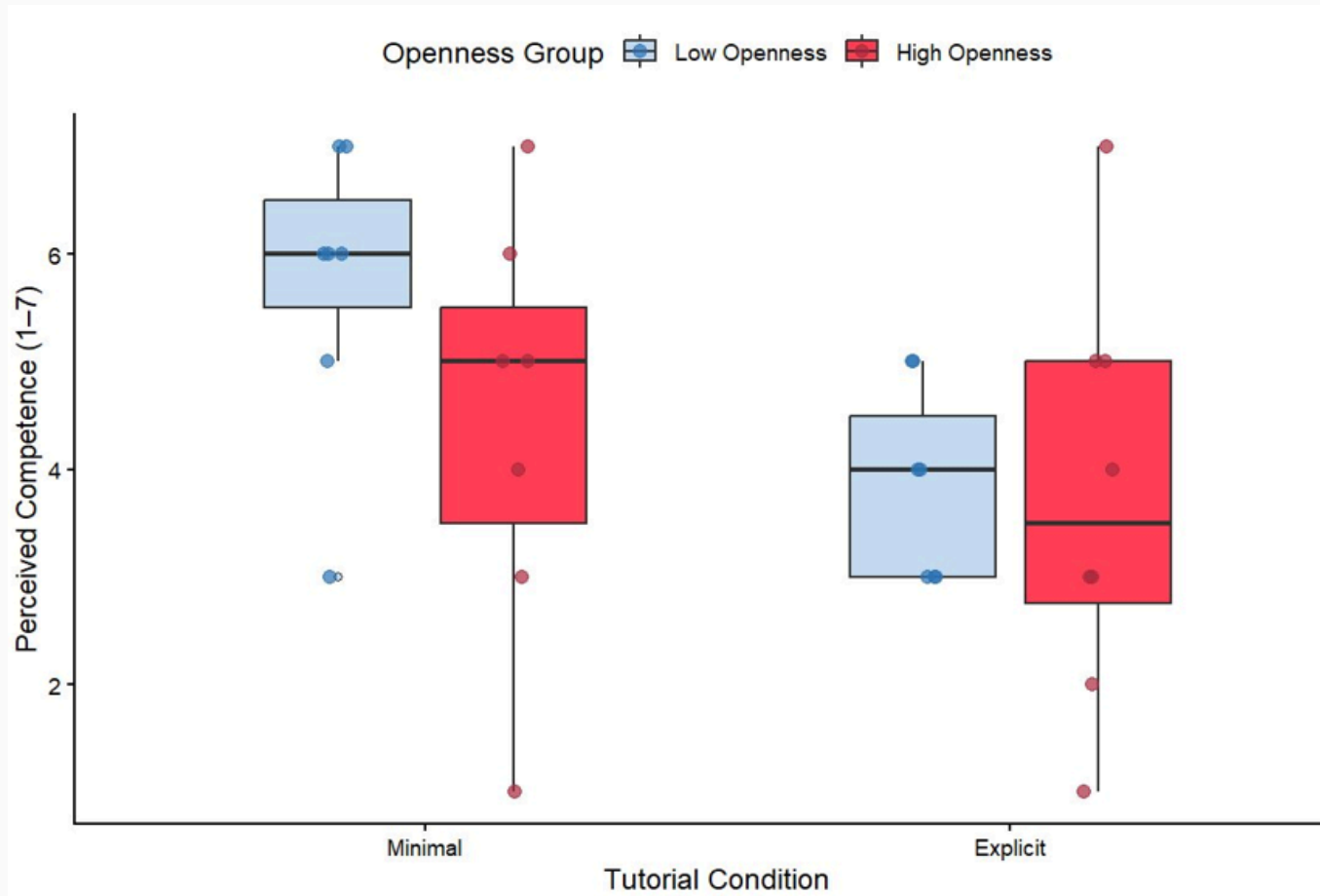
One Tutorial Doesn't Fit All Players

Does personality determine how souls-like games should teach you?



KEY FINDINGS

Figure 1. Perceived Competence by Tutorial Condition and Openness Group



ANOVA Summary (Interaction Terms)

Outcome	F(1,25)	P	η²p	BH p	Verdict
Enjoyment	0.001	0.975	<.001	0.975	Null
Perceived Competence	0.958	0.337	0.037	0.975	Null
Intention to Continue	0.069	0.795	0.003	0.975	Null

Type III SS · sum-to-zero contrasts · N = 29 (n = 7,7,7,8) · η²p values are unstable pilot estimates · BH = Benjamini-Hochberg

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

- **Person-Environment Fit (Edwards, 2008)**
Predicts mismatched conditions produce worse outcomes.
✓ A difference appeared directionally.
- **Flow Theory (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990)**
Difficulty calibration mediates experience.
✓ Consistent with the competence crossover.

LIMITATIONS & NEXT STEPS

- Observer present throughout — social desirability effects possible
- N = 29 · power ~35-55% · null ≠ no effect
- Add post-session interviews to explain competence mechanism

CONTACTS

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